

Exhibit A

A jury sealed in until the verdict is unanimous, a mother's story that will not add up, and one woman who refuses to condemn her until she knows what really happened to her child.

8:12 PM, Deliberation Room

The lock clicks shut behind us.

It's a small room for the size of the task we have been brought here to do. One window. One door, now locked. A long table, twelve chairs, a water cooler in the corner, and a strip light overhead that buzzes when it wants to be noticed. The walls are the colour of nothing in particular. And nothing to look at but each other, the table, and what sits on it.

A single photograph. A girl. Four years old. Gap-toothed, squinting up into a sun I can almost feel on my own face.

"Exhibit A," the foreman reads off the tag. "The daughter."

He sets a hand on the box beside it but does not open it. "The rest are in here. Photographs from the scene. Not something anyone would want to see twice. If you need to look, look. Otherwise, take a few minutes. Then we'll have a count."

Nobody touches the box. There seems to be a weight on the lid of it, and the same weight sits on the back of each of our necks, keeping us from reaching for it. The only thing that moves is the water cooler, bubbling up, swallowing a slow mouthful of air. The cooler sweats. A bead slides down the blue plastic, gathering others, all the way to the floor.

8:24 PM, Deliberation Room

The foreman stands. "Nobody leaves until it is unanimous. Let us see where we are."

It goes round like a plate being passed. Guilty. Guilty. Guilty. The man in the coat does not wait to be reached. "Guilty."

Obviously." He has my father's certainty, the kind that was never once wrong out loud, and sometime since we sat down I have started thinking of him as the Critic.

The woman beside me draws her cardigan closed at the throat. Carol, sixty-four, grey at the temples. She has the look of someone's good aunt, the sort who would take your side before she had heard a single fact.

"Undecided," she says. "She was asleep. You cannot take a woman's whole life for what happened while she slept."

Then me. "Undecided." My voice does not quite feel like mine. "She swears she never saw what happened. She never saw anything."

"Nobody sleeps through that," the Critic says. "Not on this earth. Not their own child going under. She was awake. She knew."

"You cannot know that," I say.

He nods at the box. "It's on the tape."

"Ten guilty," the foreman says. "Two undecided." An exhale moves round the table. Nobody argues. They only look. First at Carol, then, longer, at me, then at the box in the centre that none of us dare open.

The Critic gets up. He takes a tape from the box, slides it into the VHS player in the corner, and stabs the button with one thick finger. "She says she slept through it. So watch. Both of you."

The picture comes up grainy and grey-green, the way a cheap night camera sees. A hallway. A bathroom door, half open, light low across the floor. Very faint, you can hear a child. Humming. The small slap of a hand on water. Then nothing. I look at the Critic. I do not hate him for this. Somebody has to make us look. He is right to. It just costs me more than it costs the rest of them.

Moments later, a woman walks into frame. The mother. She moves slowly, heavily, the way you move when your body has stopped being yours, when you are on your feet and asleep at the same time. She stops at the door. She looks in. For seconds she stands there. Then she walks out of frame, and the hallway is empty.

"There," the Critic says, quietly. "She was awake."

I whisper it, barely. "But she was so sure. She was so sure she was asleep, the whole time. She told them she was asleep." A breath. "I believed her."

Nobody answers me.

I look past the grainy screen, to the black window on the wall of the deliberation room, where the night should be giving me nothing back but the room. Something small goes by on the other side of the glass. A child's height. Gap-toothed for half a breath, squinting, though there is no sun out there to squint at anymore.

When I look again it is only the window, and the room, and me in it.

8:38 PM, Deliberation Room, Recess

Sandwiches arrive on a tray and sit there untouched, curling at the corners. Carol takes the chair beside me.

"We are not meant to discuss during break," she says, and then does. "She was so tired. You could hear it, the way she said it. She was not lying about that. I believe her."

"Then you are on her side," I say.

"I am trying to be." She says it like a confession. Her comfort washes over me like a warm blanket.

Beyond the wall a door slams, heavy, metal. Then a buzzer somewhere, two long blasts, and a flat voice over a tannoy reading numbers, a name, a wing, the way you call a register.

"Did you hear that?"

Carol looks at me, kind, blank. "Hear what?"

8:51 PM, Deliberation Room

The room has gone still and sour. Nobody moves. People sit with their heads bowed and their fingers at their temples, a room full of the same headache, each one waiting for somebody else to end it.

Then Carol stands. She holds the edge of the table with both hands.

"I understand she was tired," she says, and stops.

The water cooler gurgles up into the pause.

"But she was awake," Carol says. "She was awake, and she walked past that door. When you are a mother, your child is the only thing in the world that matters." She sits. "Guilty."

Eleven, now.

The foreman comes round and crouches by my chair, gentle, as if I am the one to be handled with care and he is the voice of reason and compassion. "We cannot stay in this room forever. You know that. If we do not decide, it does not stop. It just goes on, and on, and nobody gets any peace. Not us. Not them, out there. Not you." He looks, for a second, at the box. "Not even the daughter."

When he says it, the lid of the box seems to lift ever so slightly, the way a chest lifts on a held breath, and settles. Every head in the room turns to it. The box that none of us dare open. The box that is going to stay shut.

"We cannot force you," the foreman says. "Nobody can put the word in your mouth. It is your decision, guilty or not. But it has to be said."

I look at the photograph. The girl, gap-toothed, squinting, waiting for someone to feel the same sun she felt.

"No," I say. "You are right. It should be me that says it."

I stand. The chair scrapes. Everyone goes very still.

9:00 PM, Courtroom

The well of the court is colder than the room we left, and far too quiet.

I find the faces anyway. A grandmother with a wet handkerchief twisted to rope. A young man who will not lift his eyes. And the husband and father, at the back, not crying, but wearing a

sadness so familiar that I have to look away from it before it finishes arriving.

The clerk asks whether we have reached a verdict upon which we are all agreed.

I keep my eyes on the rail. I do not look at the dock. I have never once, in all of this, been able to look at the face of the woman in it. At that version of a mother.

"Guilty," I say.

The gavel comes down.

9:05 PM, Prison Cell

It lands as a clang. The same clang. The one from beyond the wall.

"Lights out," a voice calls, far down a corridor of steel, and under it a buzzer, two long blasts, and somewhere the shouting that starts and never quite finishes. The sound runs through the bones of the building and into the frame of the bunk above me.

I lie on my back on a thin mattress. Under the bed sits the box, taped shut, the one I have never opened and never will. Above me, taped to the underside of the upper bunk and the last thing I see before the dark, the photograph.

A girl. Four. Gap-toothed, squinting up into the sun.

"Lights out."

I close my eyes.

8:12 PM, Deliberation Room

The lock clicks shut behind us.

"Exhibit A," the foreman reads. "The daughter."

"If we do not decide," the foreman says, "it does not stop. We cannot stay in this room forever."